

**Open Skies II: A Trilateral Transparency Framework
for the United States, Russia, and China**

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Executive Summary

Heightened geopolitical tensions have escalated the risk of a modern arms race among the world's major nuclear powers: the United States, Russian Federation, and People's Republic of China. Arms control is an intractable problem where reactive proliferation, fueled from escalation dynamics like each state assuming the other is stronger than they are, is not properly managed by current negotiation vectors. Track-Two dialogue lacks the enforcement and implementation mechanisms to make use of meaningful insights. Current approaches to managing the international security environment fail to equalize perceptions among nuclear states.

We propose that the United States, Russia, and China negotiate a trilateral Open Skies II treaty to restore transparency without requiring immediate arms reductions. This framework focuses on information parity rather than weapons limitation, making it politically feasible under conditions of distrust and strategic competition. By institutionalizing reciprocal aerial observation and standardized data sharing, Open Skies II creates a structured channel for ongoing engagement while avoiding the key barriers that have stalled formal disarmament negotiations.

Open Skies II would decrease misperceptions between states and contribute to arms race stability. Standardized flyovers and information sharing mechanisms means that three states will have access to the same data, allowing each state to challenge the other without compromising intelligence sources or methods. The implications are twofold. First, each state is verifiably held accountable under existing nuclear treaties (e.g., Comprehensive Nuclear Test Ban Treaty). Second, each state can conduct more accurate calculations of the other's nuclear force modernization, mitigating escalation from miscalculation or noisy signals.

Introduction: Diverging Perspectives on Stability

Previous generations managed nuclear stability primarily through bilateral arms control agreements. Today, however, strategic competition among the United States, Russia, and China has made such frameworks increasingly difficult to sustain, while simultaneously intensifying the risks of misperception and escalation. The question is: how do U.S. perceptions of topics like nuclear use, deterrence, stability, and the spectrum of conflict compare to those of its competitors? What risks arise in the differences among those perspectives and how can we mitigate them?

A primary contradiction between the United States and Russia arises in their different perspectives on stability. Diverging perspectives on stability, China's distinct approach to nuclear development, and reluctance by all parties to engage in traditional arms limitation talks now create a trilateral environment in which states interpret each other's actions through incompatible strategic lenses. As a result, there is more uncertainty around nuclear capability and intent is not mitigated by diplomatic frameworks or verification mechanisms in the status quo.

Absent institutions enabling the great power triad from sharing common information on each other's nuclear programs, no state is able to address violations of existing nuclear treaties nor verify the intent of nuclear developments. One motivating example was the United States release of a seismology graph from 2022 and an accusation that China tested nuclear weapons that were not identified by the CTBTO. China outright denies the accusation that they were conducting nuclear tests, but without existing diplomatic channels there is a gap of trust (Foundation for Defense of Democracies, 2026). This dynamic illustrates a broader problem: policymakers must make high-stakes decisions based on incomplete or disputed information, increasing the likelihood of arms racing or crisis escalation.

Three competing policy approaches are considered as a means to alleviate the pressure caused by misperceptions: arms control treaty, Track-Two discussions, and Open Skies. While each offers a potential pathway to reducing uncertainty, we evaluate each option on a basis of its viability, verifiability, and probability of reducing misperceptions.

The Open Skies Treaty was signed in 1992 with 34 member states, permitting each member state to conduct short notice unarmed surveillance flyovers to collect data on military forces and activity. In 2020 the United States withdrew from Open Skies alleging Russian non-compliance and Russia withdrew in 2021 in retaliation (Arms Control Association, 2022). Although Open Skies continues to operate primarily between European partners, the viability of the great power triad (re-)joining the original treaty is very low. The United States would face political costs for reneging on its decision to leave, Russia remains skeptical of providing Europeans military data while at war, and China is skeptical of programs increasing its military transparency (O’Hanlon, 2023).

We argue that the United States, Russia, and China should establish a trilateral Open Skies II treaty enabling party members to conduct regularized flyover of other party members nuclear sites, data sharing, and standardized resolution controls in order to reduce misperceptions of adversary nuclear use and nuclear development, thereby reducing the risk of arms race or crisis escalation.

Background: Historical and Modern Arms Racing

In 2014, Russia’s invasion and annexation of Crimea marked the end of the U.S.-Russia reset and the beginning of international instability. Since 2018, American and Russian withdrawals from bilateral nuclear treaties, starting with the Intermediate-Range Nuclear Forces

Treaty, have culminated in the end of the New Strategic Arms Reduction Treaty in 2026 when the states allowed the agreement to sunset without replacement (NATO, 2025). Simultaneously, the People's Republic of China signaled a marked shift in their nuclear posture beginning in the summer of 2021, complicating any future path for nuclear negotiations (Stålhane & Taylor, n.d.). The result is that the world's major nuclear weapon states are barreling toward a new arms race and breakdowns in each state's perceptions of the other's activities yield an increased risk of crisis escalation potentially triggering nuclear war ("A New Nuclear Arms Race Looms," n.d.; Nuclear Risks Grow as New Arms Race Looms—New SIPRI Yearbook out Now | SIPRI, 2025; The Growing Push to Halt and Reverse the New Nuclear Arms Race | Arms Control Association, n.d.).

During the Cold War, perceived imbalances in nuclear capabilities played a central role in driving the arms race. Beginning in the late 1950s, U.S. politicians warned of a looming "missile gap," claiming the Soviet Union was deploying hundreds of ICBMs, when declassified intelligence later showed Moscow had only a handful while the United States rapidly expanded its arsenal (Thielmann, 2011; Licklider, 1970). Because Washington could not reveal sensitive sources and methods, worst-case public estimates went largely unchallenged, justifying major nuclear buildups and more aggressive postures. This episode illustrates how politicized narratives and constraints on sharing intelligence can turn misperceptions into concrete arms-race dynamics. That is precisely the risk now emerging among the U.S., Russia, and China.

Today's escalation risks diverge from the Cold War in at least two key ways. First, there are now three central nuclear players: the United States, Russia, and China, whose decisions most directly shape great power arms race dynamics. Other nuclear-armed states remain relevant as regional actors, but bringing them formally into a new transparency or arms-control

framework would significantly complicate negotiations and reduce overall viability. Our analysis therefore focuses on the great-power triad while assuming that greater stability among these three would benefit other nuclear states by lowering the risk of major-power nuclear war.

The second major difference between contemporary and Cold War arms race dynamics is that the earlier crisis was characterized primarily by quantitative proliferation of nuclear weapons under the logic of mutually assured destruction. Today, nuclear modernization is increasingly qualitative, and these changes undermine the classic mutually assured destruction analogy. The United States, under the second Trump administration, has pursued a layered missile defense system that, if effective, could weaken mutual vulnerability by defending U.S. territory against ballistic, hypersonic, and cruise missile threats, the main delivery platforms for nuclear warheads (Carnegie Endowment for International Peace, 2024). Both Russia and China are also investing in qualitative advancements, including new generations of low-yield tactical nuclear weapons that may be perceived as usable below the threshold of reciprocal annihilation, encouraging cost-benefit calculations about limited nuclear use (Kimball, 2024; U.S. Department of Defense, 2024). In parallel, Russia's doctrinal shifts toward authorizing nuclear use against certain non-nuclear threats further blur traditional thresholds, making accurate, shared information about force posture and deployments more critical for preventing misperception and escalation.

American Doctrine

Since New START was ratified in 2010, the United States has reduced deployed strategic warheads while modernizing its arsenal to maintain a credible deterrent. With the treaty's expiration and the rise of China as a significant nuclear competitor, U.S. officials now argue that purely bilateral limits with Russia are insufficient and that both Moscow and Beijing have

violated test-ban and related commitments (Jenkins, 2026). This shift makes new arms-reduction treaties politically difficult, but increases the importance of alternative mechanisms.

Chinese Doctrine

China is rapidly expanding and modernizing its nuclear forces, with its warhead stockpile roughly doubling in recent years as Beijing seeks a more secure second-strike capability comparable to the United States and Russia. (Chen, 2026; U.S. Department of Defense, 2024). Chinese leaders justify this buildup as necessary to "safeguard the country's strategic security and to counter perceived Western pressure (Carnegie Endowment for International Peace, 2024). Simultaneously, they have signaled a shift away from a longstanding no-first-use policy raising global security questions (Pan, 2018). China has never joined formal arms reduction treaties because it remains wary of constraints designed around much larger U.S. and Russian arsenals.

Russian Doctrine

Russia has repeatedly revised its nuclear doctrine over the past 15 years, including during the war in Ukraine, and now outlines a broad set of contingencies in which nuclear weapons could be used, potentially including against non-nuclear threats (Brookings Institution, 2024; Kimball, 2024).. While U.S. officials view these changes as irresponsible and escalatory, Moscow frames its nuclear posture as essential to safeguarding sovereignty and deterring Western encroachment, reinforcing a siege mentality (Schneider, 2025). The lack of sustained strategic dialogue, combined with U.S. emphasis on low-yield options in its own posture, has produced an iterative lowering of perceived nuclear-use thresholds on both sides (Korda, 2022), increasing the value of verifiable transparency measures that can help distinguish routine activity from preparations for escalation.

How Countries See Each Other

The 2024 U.S. report to Congress on China's military and security developments frames Chinese "information operations (IO) and disinformation campaigns" in Southeast Asia as contributing to nuclear proliferation risk and undermining regional stability (U.S. Department of Defense, 2024). These narratives, alongside Chinese and Russian claims that U.S. accusations are politically motivated, deepen mutual distrust and make it harder for leaders to reach shared assessments of nuclear-related activity. In this context, argued threats and counter-threats increasingly rest on contested information, underscoring the value of a regime like Open Skies II that generates common, treaty-governed imagery rather than dueling intelligence claims.

Current Approaches

The Open Skies Treaty is an international arms control agreement that permits signatory nations to conduct short-notice unarmed observation flights over the entire territory. The Treaty's primary objective is to ensure mutual understanding and trust between all nation-states party to this treaty, which serves as a direct role in garnering military information and its respective activities. Observation aircraft would be provided either by the observing party or the observed party. One of the primary means that nation-states fulfill their agreement to the treaty is through making the territory accessible to aerial observation and that observation flights may not be blocked due to national security rationale. If there are flight safety issues present, then an observation flight may be restricted. Sensors are also a critical component of ensuring nation-states comply with the treaty, where aircraft are permitted to have video cameras and panoramic features for daylight photography. In terms of including night-time photography, infra-red line scanning and synthetic aperture radar (which can also be operated in any weather conditions). Finally, the final component essential to the Open Skies Treaty is quotas, which is

the number of observation flights that a nation-state is willing to accept annually and are scaled to the nation-state's size. Each State Party will have a representative that will meet in Vienna discussing any possible issues and to monitor the Treaty's operation. All data collected will be available to all parties involved, where other state parties who are not involved are able to purchase copies of data. With all of these different factors combined, the Treaty is intended to enhance security and assurance among the nation-states involved and to promote stability in the international sphere (Congressional Research Service, 2025).

Decision Matrix			
	Viability	Verifiability	Reduce Misperceptions
Open Skies II	Probable Technology and policy precedent exists. No limitation on nuclear posture.	Highly Probable Established infrastructure including specifications, aircraft, and resolution. Certification procedure exists	Probable Not better than NTM. Provides common data that can be openly discussed by parties.
Arms Control Treaty	Unlikely China is hardline against limitations. The U.S. is hardline against bilateral agreements.	Probable Verification mechanisms exist and were implemented in prior treaties. Limited by treaty language and meeting obligations.	Highly Probable
Track Two	Probable U.S.–Chinese track two dialogues in place. U.S.–Russia Track Two meetings held by Stimson and NCAFP.	Extremely Unlikely Unofficial dialogue does not automatically force government action.	Probable Establishes more channels of communication.
Open Skies I	Highly Unlikely Western European access to imagery in Russia is a non-starter. Would require Russian–European brokerage.	Probable Same verification mechanisms as the original treaty.	Probable Would reduce misperceptions if all three great powers join. Limited provisions to allow states to purchase data from each other.
Status Quo	Highly Probable No cooperation mechanism is in place, requiring the least effort.	Unlikely States are not able to verify and compare intelligence without exposing sources and methods.	Highly Unlikely Without shared data or verification, states' information is limited and disrupted.

Proposed Policy: Open Skies Treaty II

Arms control treaties like New START, which enabled strategic arms reductions and transparent verification of deployed warheads, have lapsed, and the United States, Russia, and China now bring conflicting demands to any future negotiations. In this environment, traditional arms control is not currently viable, but a new framework for structured diplomatic engagement is necessary to reduce misperceptions and manage escalation risk. We assess alternative approaches using three criteria: the extent to which they reduce nuclear misperceptions, their political and practical feasibility, and their verifiability. The status quo is characterized by minimal communication about strategic matters among the three major nuclear states, which is dangerous because policymakers increasingly rely on flawed historical analogies that can distort risk assessments and decisionmaking (Gavin, 2025). Our proposal is to negotiate a trilateral Open Skies II treaty that reopens diplomatic channels and permits reciprocal observation flights over each party's territory focused on nuclear-related activity.

Such a regime would limit nuclear miscalculation in at least three ways. First, it would increase transparency regarding troop movements, bases, and military deployments, making large-scale preparations for surprise attack more difficult to conceal. Second, it would provide each state with the same certified, treaty-governed imagery, reducing disputes about “what is really happening” on the ground and mitigating the need to expose sensitive sources and methods when challenging suspected violations (Bell & Wier, 2019). Finally, by generating a shared evidentiary baseline, Open Skies II would lower uncertainty and decrease the odds that routine exercises or deployments are misinterpreted as preparations for nuclear use.

For the United States, the central challenge is political viability. Washington's 2020 withdrawal from the original Open Skies Treaty, citing Russian noncompliance and restrictions

on flights over sensitive areas, has created strong domestic skepticism about returning to any similar regime (U.S. Department of State, 2020). An Open Skies Treaty II therefore would have to prioritize treaty compliance to garner domestic American support. This treaty is designed to incentivize compliance more than Open Skies I since it explicitly removes the Western European concern that motivated Russian non-compliance in the original agreement.

For Russia, the viability of Open Skies II is shaped by a legacy of perceived humiliation in the post–Cold War order and by the current war in Ukraine. Many Russians, including Vladimir Putin, view the 1990s as a decade in which the United States imposed its vision of European security, and Moscow often interprets Western transparency demands as instruments of political pressure rather than mutual stabilizers (Goldgeier, 2024; Sokov & Woolf, 2024). Although the Ukraine war heightens Russian concern that aerial observation could expose aspects of its military posture, Russia’s extensive experience with the original Open Skies procedures means verifiability is not a technical obstacle; a regime focused on nuclear-relevant facilities with equal access and shared imagery could help correct misperceptions while allowing Moscow to contest Western narratives without accepting new warhead limits.

For China, the main constraint on participation is a refusal to enter U.S.–Russia-style disarmament talks while its arsenal remains significantly smaller, not opposition to all forms of transparency. Beijing has consistently rejected joining traditional arms control negotiations but has engaged in informal confidence-building measures, including launch notifications and bilateral agreements with Russia related to ballistic missile tests. A carefully designed Open Skies II that avoids numerical caps, limits observation to agreed nuclear-related sites, and guarantees standardized, shared imagery would thus be politically more acceptable for China,

offering a way to monitor U.S. and Russian modernization while reducing misperceptions about its own posture.

Constituencies, Roadblocks, and Barriers

The Department of State's Bureau of Arms Control, Deterrence, and Stability would lead treaty negotiation and diplomatic coordination. Within the bureau, the Office of Multilateral and Nuclear Affairs would likely handle the negotiation of an Open Skies II framework. Operational implementation would then fall to the Department of Defense, specifically the Defense Threat Reduction Agency's Open Skies Division, which historically managed training, mission support, coordination, and leadership for U.S. Open Skies activity.

The main U.S. barrier is political ratification and domestic skepticism. Any new treaty would need Senate advice and consent, and a bipartisan minority could argue that Open Skies exposes sensitive facilities while providing few tangible constraints on adversaries (U.S. Senate Committee on Foreign Relations, 2024). Moreover, the program might be described as kicking the can down the road and making the chances of striking a "real" arms control deal less likely; any of these political sentiments would hurt the viability of American implementation. A second barrier is that U.S. officials now associate Open Skies with Russian noncompliance, especially following disputes over denied flights and alleged misuse of treaty privileges (Hawkins, 2021). A third barrier is bureaucratic caution: even supporters may worry that the treaty may not have enforceable strategic payoff.

The Russian Ministry of Foreign Affairs would likely lead diplomacy and treaty coordination, while the Ministry of Defense would manage operational flight participation and military implementation. Russia's Open Skies participation has historically operated through Foreign Ministry representatives working inside the treaty's consultative mechanism. Domestic

implementation would require coordination between foreign policy officials and defense officials responsible for air operations and compliance.

The primary Russian barrier to this agreement is a deep degree of distrust. Moscow has repeatedly framed Western arm-control pressure as politically motivated and has treated U.S. claims of Russian noncompliance as selective or coercive (Finnish Institute of International Affairs, 2020). A second barrier is the ongoing war in Ukraine, which makes Russian leaders less likely to accept a transparency measure that could reveal force posture, deployments, or military preparation. A third barrier is that Russia may want any agreement to come with reciprocal concession, which could slow or block agreements when the U.S. refuses to trade away any other positions.

China's Ministry of Foreign Affairs would likely serve as the diplomatic lead, while the Ministry of National Defense and the People's Liberation Army Air Force would handle technical execution and access coordination. Because China already uses its foreign ministry for strategic messaging and notifications, it is the most plausible entry point for treaty negotiation. Operational responsibilities would then fall to defense and air force authorities.

The main Chinese barrier is its desire to preserve ambiguity about the size and location of its nuclear force. China has historically been reluctant to join arms control regimes that seem built around the larger U.S.-Russian arsenals. A second barrier is that Chinese leaders may fear transparency will weaken deterrence by revealing too much about modernization or basing (Zhang, 2001). A third barrier is that China may suspect the treaty is a disguised effort to constrain its rise rather than a neutral confidence-building measure (Budryk, 2020).

The Open Skies Consultative Commission is a multilateral implementation body composed of representatives from each state party and operating by consensus. Open Skies II

would likely follow the same model, with designated representatives from the United States, Russia, and China and a small technical secretariat to manage scheduling, imagery standards, disputes, and compliance documentation.

The Open Skies Consultative Commission's greatest challenge would be consensus management. The OSCC works by consensus, which means a single state can slow decisions, or block procedural changes (Nuclear Threat Initiative, 2020; Organization for Security and Co-operation in Europe, 2002). Another barrier is that a trilateral body would need a trusted technical secretariat: the more capable the secretariat is, the more each party may worry it is being used for intelligence advantage.

There are a few joint obstacles beyond country barriers. Once a technical body is established, the triad needs to procure proper aircraft and standardized sensors, maintain records of flight quotas, airspace permissions, and equipment verification, as well as distribute costs of maintaining the trilateral regime and communication infrastructure. Though the United States and Russia have aircraft that were previously used during the Open Skies Treaty, they are out of date and would need updated certification. The triad would need to agree upon a common aircraft for Chinese overflight. Establishing a new Open Skies while disregarding still participating states may also lead to political pushback.

Conclusion: Open Skies II for Enhanced Stability

The proposed Open Skies II offers a politically feasible way to rebuild nuclear transparency in a competitive, mistrustful environment without demanding immediate arsenal cuts. By generating standardized, shareable data and imagery across the U.S., Russia, and China triad, it reduces the room for contested intelligence narratives and limits the risk that worst-case assumptions drive arms racing or crisis escalation. The treaty leverages existing technical and

institutional precedents while tailoring participation and access rules to the specific concerns of all three great powers. Although political and bureaucratic hurdles in each capital are significant, none are insurmountable if the treaty is framed as a limited confidence-building measure rather than a disarmament bargain. In a world where traditional arms control has stalled, Open Skies II is a pragmatic step that can slow escalatory dynamics and keep the door open for more ambitious agreements in the future.

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